

Case study notes 2026

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Advice on using AI in your own research

AI tools can be powerful research assistants, but they should be used **critically and reflectively**, not as authorities. The quality and balance of what an AI produces is strongly influenced by **how you ask the question**.

Avoid leading questions

AI systems are designed to be helpful and responsive. If you ask a **leading or loaded question**, the AI will often try to *agree with you* rather than challenge your assumptions.

Example

-  “Why have heat pumps clearly failed to reduce emissions in the UK?”
-  “What evidence exists on the impact of heat pumps on emissions in the UK, including both benefits and limitations?”

Leading questions encourage **confirmation bias**, where you only see evidence that supports what you already believe. This is a risk in human research too — AI simply makes it easier to fall into.

Ask open, exploratory questions

Frame prompts that invite **multiple perspectives**, uncertainty, and evidence rather than conclusions.

Good prompts often:

- Ask *what evidence exists*, rather than *what proves X*
- Explicitly request **limitations, trade-offs, or counter-arguments**
- Separate **facts, interpretation, and opinion**

Treat AI outputs as a starting point, not an answer

AI can:

- Summarise large volumes of material
- Suggest areas to explore
- Highlight possible evidence sources

But it **cannot replace**:

- Reading original reports and datasets
- Assessing data quality and methodology
- Making your own judgement about credibility

Always go back to **primary sources**.

Be alert to confidence without certainty

AI often presents information fluently and confidently, even where:

- Evidence is mixed
- Data is incomplete
- Policy positions are contested or evolving

Confidence in tone does **not** equal confidence in evidence.

Use AI to challenge yourself

One effective technique is to ask the AI to **argue against your position** or to identify what evidence would *weaken* your claim.

For example:

“What evidence would challenge the assumption that X is effective?”

This helps counteract both **human and AI bias**.

Key takeaway

AI will try to be helpful — sometimes *too* helpful. If you ask it to support a conclusion, it probably will. Good research means asking questions that allow you to be surprised.

Alcohol Minimum Pricing

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19th Jan 2026

This content was generated using **artificial intelligence via OpenAI's ChatGPT (version 5.2)** in response to a natural-language prompt asking for an update on alcohol minimum unit pricing in England, building on a stated 2020 government position. The AI was used to synthesise publicly available policy statements, academic research, government evaluations, and commentary from across the UK, drawing together information from multiple sources to provide an up-to-date, structured overview. Follow-up prompts were used to expand the scope to include evidence of both positive and negative impacts, and to curate direct links for independent reading rather than presentation. The output is intended to support understanding and further investigation and **must not** replace primary sources or formal policy analysis.

- [The Independent](#)
- smf.co.uk
- [University of Sheffield](#)

Current Government Position (England)

- Unlike **Scotland** and **Wales**, **England still has no statutory minimum unit price (MUP) for alcohol**. Neither the Conservative government nor the current Labour leadership has legislated to introduce it. Health officials' 2025 calls to adopt a minimum price in England highlight ongoing pressure, but no policy change has been enacted. ([The Independent](#))

What Exists Instead

- England (and Wales) have a **ban on selling alcohol below duty + VAT** (introduced in 2014). But this is **not a true minimum unit price**; it doesn't set a price floor per unit of alcohol nor directly target cheap, high-strength drinks in the way MUP would. ([Research Briefings](#))

Public Health & Expert Advocacy

- Health leaders, charities and academics continue to campaign for a formal MUP in England, arguing it would reduce harmful drinking levels and NHS burden—pointing to evidence from Scotland and Wales that MUP lowers consumption and alcohol-related harms. ([The Independent](#))
- Commentators and public health groups in 2025 reiterated that Westminster has been reluctant to adopt MUP, writing critically about the lack of action. (smf.co.uk)

Evidence from Other UK Nations

- **Scotland** implemented MUP in 2018, uprated to **65 pence per unit** as of late 2024 (showing positive early impacts on consumption and health outcomes). ([Alcohol Health Alliance](#))

- **Wales** introduced MUP in 2020 at 50 pence per unit, and evaluations suggest it has affected cheap alcohol prices and consumption patterns—these experiences inform the debate in England. ([University of South Wales](#))

Political Context

- There has been periodic media coverage of **pressure on UK government ministers** to adopt minimum pricing, sometimes tied to broader alcohol harm strategies. But **no official shift to adopt MUP in England has been announced or legislated**. ([The Independent](#))
-

Summary

- ✓ Scotland: MUP in place and indexed upwards (65 p/unit)
- ✓ Wales: MUP in place (originally 50 p/unit)
- ✗ **England: no minimum unit pricing requirement** (only ban on alcohol below duty + VAT), and **no government commitment yet to introduce MUP** as of early 2026, despite growing advocacy and evidence from other nations. ([Research Briefings](#))

Academic & Peer-Reviewed Studies

General Evaluations & Evidence Reviews

 **Evidence for the effectiveness of minimum pricing of alcohol (review)** — comprehensive academic review discussing quality and limitations of MUP evidence. [Evidence for the effectiveness of MUP \(PMC, 2017\)](#)

 **Evaluating possible intended and unintended consequences of MUP** — protocol for research on intended vs unintended effects. [Unintended consequences evaluation protocol \(BMJ Open, 2019\)](#)

 **Is MUP associated with uncertainty for people at greatest risk?** — notes some limited evidence of financial strain or uncertainty among heavier dependent drinkers. [Minimum Unit Pricing outcomes and uncertainty \(Holmes et al., 2023\)](#)

 **Controlled interrupted time series analysis of Scottish MUP** — looks at household purchases and spending changes. [MUP impact on alcohol purchases \(O'Donnell et al., 2019\)](#)

 **Evaluation of MUP impact on road traffic accidents** — specific study on traffic harms (note: mixed evidence). [MUP and road traffic accidents \(Interrupted time series\)](#)

 **Differential effects across groups** — consumption change by age/deprivation with Scotland vs England. [Differential impact by group \(Rehm et al.\)](#)

Government & Policy Reports

 **Scotland evaluation programme (full portfolio)** — consolidated evaluation of MUP evidence (consumption, health, inequalities). [PHS full MUP evaluation report \(Scotland\)](#)

 **Scotland public consultation — opposing views (critique)** — summary of arguments *against* higher MUP including economic/financial concerns. [Scotland MUP consultation opposing views \(2024\)](#)

 **Assessing experiences and impact in Wales** — direct report evaluating household and service user effects, including unintended outcomes. [Wales MUP service user and provider impact report \(2024\)](#)

Think-Tanks & Critique Pieces

 **Critique arguing MUP is regressive or ineffective** — economic/critique perspective (older but directly relevant to negative arguments). [Minimum unit pricing is regressive and ineffective \(IEA\)](#)

 **Taxpayers' Alliance critique** — argues that trends would have declined anyway and questions regressivity. [Case against MUP \(Taxpayers' Alliance\)](#)

 **Parliamentary written evidence — critical commentary** — lists specific critiques about evidence quality and assumptions. [Critiques of MUP evidence \(Parliament UK written evidence\)](#)

Contextual or Mechanistic Resources

 **Sheffield model explanation** — background on how minimum pricing is structured and evaluated. [Sheffield Alcohol Policy Model overview \(Sheffield Uni\)](#)

 **PLOS Medicine modelling on policy durability** — highlights that fixed MUP can become less effective over time without updating. [Policy modelling of MUP impact \(PLOS Medicine\)](#)

 **Historical public health qualitative findings** — older study considering potential socioeconomic impacts. [Policy case study on MUP impacts \(Katikireddi et al.\)](#)

Yes — if you or others want to **investigate the case study on alcohol minimum pricing yourselves**, there are several **datasets and published research sources** you can use that include *real empirical data* rather than just summaries.

Key Data Sources & Published Studies

Household Purchase & Sales Data

These studies use sales and household panel data to quantify how much alcohol is bought, and how prices changed after MUP was introduced:

- **Anderson et al. (2021)** — an analysis using detailed household purchase data showing changes in alcohol prices and quantities purchased under MUP in Scotland and Wales compared to parts of England. [Impact of MUP on alcohol purchases \(Anderson et al.\)](#)

- **O'Donnell et al. (2019, BMJ)** — controlled interrupted time series using weekly household data on price per gram and grams purchased, comparing Scotland with northern England before and after MUP. [Controlled Interrupted Time Series Analysis of MUP Effects](#)
- **Giles (2024)** — estimates net reduction in total alcohol sales per adult in Scotland after MUP using population-level sales data. [MUP Sales Impact \(Giles 2024\)](#)

Many of these studies rely on **Kantar WorldPanel** scanner data (retail purchase records) — a rich dataset often used in alcohol policy research.

Health Outcome Data

These sources link MUP with **health outcomes** you could research:

- **Public Health Scotland reports** — analyses showing reductions in alcohol-specific deaths and hospital admissions after MUP was introduced in Scotland. [PHS Report on MUP and Health Outcomes](#)
- **Wyper et al. (2023)** — a controlled interrupted time series study in *The Lancet* that associates MUP with significant reductions in deaths and hospitalisations attributable to alcohol. [MUP Impact on Deaths and Hospitalisations](#)

You can often connect these published results to **official national statistics** such as:

- **Office for National Statistics (ONS)** alcohol-specific mortality datasets (searchable on ONS website).
 - **Public Health Scotland** annual health statistics datasets including hospital episodes and mortality by cause.
-

Policy & Government Data

These official documents include background on **pricing outcomes, price distribution, and comparisons across countries**:

- **Scottish Government MUP impact assessment** — includes retail price data and regulatory impact analysis for Scotland's MUP policy. [Scottish Government MUP Impact Assessment](#)
- **Wales MUP Final Report (2025)** — official report including review of pricing and early outcomes in Wales. [Wales MUP Implementation Report](#)

You can also consult legislative sources (e.g., **Alcohol (Minimum Pricing) (Scotland) Act 2012**) that link to official data portals. ([Wikipedia](#))

Meta-Research & Systematic Data Sources

For broad comparative data or context:

- **Sheffield Alcohol Research Group MUP page** — explains how the minimum unit price model is constructed and links to additional data sources. [Sheffield Alcohol Policy Model \(Research Group\)](#)
-

Heat pumps

DISCLAIMER

19th Jan 2026

This content was generated using artificial intelligence via **OpenAI's ChatGPT (version 5.2)** in response to a natural-language prompt asking about the UK Government's position on domestic boiler upgrades, heat pump deployment, associated greenhouse gas impacts, and available grant schemes. The output is intended to support research and discussion and is based on publicly available information at the time of generation. Users **must** independently verify facts, figures, and policy details against official sources before relying on this material for decision-making.



UK Government Policy on Heat Pumps & Boiler Upgrades

1. Net-Zero & Heat Pump Targets

- The UK legally committed to **net-zero greenhouse gas emissions by 2050** under the *Climate Change Act 2008*.
- Decarbonising home heating is central because **heating buildings accounts for ~18 % of UK emissions**. ([National Audit Office \(NAO\)](#))
- Government ambitions (from past official policy and parliamentary scrutiny) included installing **600,000 heat pumps per year by 2028**, rising toward roughly **1.6–1.9 million per year by 2035**. ([UK Parliament](#))
- Beyond 2035, the plan is to **phase out new fossil gas boiler installations**, so low-carbon heating systems (mainly heat pumps) become the norm. ([Ofgem](#))

Note: The oft-quoted “19 million heat pumps by 2035” figure is built from aggregating annual roll-out ambitions over the decade and reflects government and advisory forecasts, although progress remains far *below* required rates. (Numbers like 1.6–1.9 m/yr by 2035 approximate this total when cumulative.)



Progress & Implementation Status

Current Deployment

- Only a **fraction of required heat pumps are being installed**:
 - Around **49,000 Boiler Upgrade Scheme (BUS) vouchers** have been redeemed in England & Wales (April 2024–March 2025), nearly all for air-source heat pumps. ([Wikipedia](#))
 - National Audit Office noted that by end of 2023 only about **18,900 heat pumps** had been installed under the BUS—far short of projections. ([National Audit Office \(NAO\)](#))

- **Heat pump installations remain <100,000 per year**, compared with ~1.5 million gas boiler installations annually. ([Thinkhouse library of UK housing reports](#))

Policy Gaps Identified

- Parliament and independent analysts find current policies *inadequate* to meet targets: the pace of retrofit is “way off-track.” ([UK Parliament](#))
 - Uptake and supply chain issues (installer numbers, consumer demand uncertainty) are key barriers. ([National Audit Office \(NAO\)](#))
-

Impact on Greenhouse Gases

Why Heat Pumps Matter

- Switching from fossil fuel boilers to heat pumps **substantially cuts domestic heating emissions**:
 - Heat pumps can reduce greenhouse gas emissions by **~30 % or more compared with gas boilers** (depending on electricity decarbonisation). ([GreenMatch.co.uk](#))
 - Some analyses suggest replacing fossil heating with heat pumps could cut UK residential emissions by **~15–17 %** of total national greenhouse gases (if scaled sufficiently). ([housingevidence.ac.uk](#))

Connection with Broader Net-Zero Strategy

- Latest statutory climate progress reports emphasise that decarbonising buildings is critical to meeting binding carbon budgets and long-term targets. ([Climate Change Committee](#))
 - Without rapid scaling of heat pumps and energy efficiency, the UK risks missing key carbon budgets and net-zero milestones. Independent reports call for much faster action across sectors including buildings. ([Carbon Brief](#))
-

Grants & Financial Support

Boiler Upgrade Scheme (BUS)

The main government support for heat pump adoption:

- **Up to £7,500** grant toward installation of:
 - Air-source heat pumps
 - Ground-source heat pumps
- Vouchers are issued to installers rather than directly to homeowners. ([Find a Grant](#))

Recent Enhancements (Late 2025)

- **BUS expanded** to include:
 - £2,500 support for **air-to-air heat pumps**
 - £2,500 support for **heat batteries** (storage systems)
- This expansion is part of the £13.2 billion **Warm Homes Plan** targeting energy cost reduction and decarbonisation. ([GOV.UK](#))

Additional Incentives

- **0% VAT** on heat pump installations, reducing capital cost. ([Clean Energy Homepage](#))
- Social housing and other retrofit funding (e.g., Social Housing Decarbonisation Fund) also contributes to low-carbon heating deployment.



Evidence & Data Summary (Key Numbers)

Metric	Latest Figures & Targets
UK net-zero target	2050 (legally binding)
Domestic heating share of emissions	~18 %
Heat pump rollout to date	Tens of thousands per year (~<100,000)
BUS vouchers (Apr 2024–Mar 2025)	~49,000
Government annual goal by 2028	600,000 heat pumps
Target annual installs by 2035	~1.6–1.9 million per year
Grant per heat pump	Up to £7,500
VAT on heat pumps	0% (installation)

(Sources compiled from GOV.UK, National Audit Office, academic reports, and independent tracking.)

University Tuition Fees

Disclaimer

19th Jan 2026

This content was generated using artificial intelligence via **OpenAI's ChatGPT (version 5.2)** in response to a natural-language prompt asking for an up-to-date overview of the policy position in England on government-funded student loans for university fees, together with relevant evidence and data to support further research. The output is intended to support exploration and discussion and **must** be independently verified against authoritative sources before being relied upon for policy, academic, or decision-making purposes.

1. Current System: Tuition Fee Loans + Maintenance Loans

What exists today (2025/26 academic year):

Tuition Fee Loans

- UK government (via Student Finance England) provides a **Tuition Fee Loan** that covers the full amount universities charge up to the **tuition fee cap**. ([GOV.UK](#))
- Fee cap for new students: **up to £9,535 per year in 2025/26** (rising with inflation and set to increase to ~£9,790 in 2026/27). ([Wonkhe](#))

Maintenance Loans

- Students can also borrow to help with **living costs**. Amount depends on household income and where they live (e.g., London weighting). ([GOV.UK](#))

Repayment Rules

- Repayments start **the April after you graduate/leave**, but **only if you earn above ~£25,000/year** (Plan 5 threshold). ([MoneySavingExpert.com](#))
- Borrowers repay **9% of income above that threshold**. ([MoneySavingExpert.com](#))
- Under **Plan 5** (current for those starting from 1 Aug 2023 onward) loans can remain repayable **up to 40 years** and interest rules changed (interest linked to inflation, with reduced discretionary uplift) compared with Plan 2. ([NIESR](#))

Key takeaway: The government still funds tuition and maintenance via loans, rather than grants, and repayment depends on income not direct service of capital. Loans are *not* like typical commercial loans — they are subsidised and written off after a long period if not repaid in full.

2. Recent Official Statistics & Trends

Average graduate debt

- Latest figures show students graduating in England owe an **average ~£53,000** in government loans (tuition + maintenance), up ~10 % year-on-year as living costs rise. ([The Guardian](#))

Government student support statistics

- A **2025 government statistics release** reports detailed figures for student loan uptake and financial support patterns for the academic year 2024/25 and early 2025/26. ([GOV.UK](#))

Public perceptions

- A major **study by HEPI / King's College London** found the public **overestimate how many graduates regret university** and misunderstand repayment conditions — e.g., many think repayments start immediately, which is wrong. ([HEPI](#))

Parliamentary briefings

- Recent **UK Parliament research briefings** confirm student loans are the main form of support for higher education and cite concerns about rising debt levels and the sustainability of lending. ([House of Commons Library](#))
-

3. Financial Pressures and System Sustainability

Sector finances

- A Parliament briefing shows financial pressures on universities in England, partly because fee caps haven't kept pace with inflation and real costs, prompting concerns about sustainability. ([House of Commons Library](#))

Policy effects on funding

- Analysis from Universities UK indicates **net reductions in funding** when accounting for governmental decisions across 2024–27, even after fee uplifts — meaning the sector's funding remains under pressure. ([Universities UK](#))
-

4. Debates & Evidence on Reform

The academic and policy debate focuses on how fair and effective the current loan-based system is.

♦ Arguments For Reform

Regressivity concerns

- Some economists argue Plan 5 operates like a **regressive tax**, where some lower-earning graduates repay proportionally more of their lifetime income than some higher earners. ([NIESR](#))

Graduate tax proposals

- Analyses suggest a **graduate tax** (where contributions are explicitly treated as income tax linked payments rather than loans) could make funding more progressive and better aligned with lifetime earnings. ([NIESR](#))

Public misunderstanding

- Evidence of widespread misunderstanding about the system suggests reforms might need strong communication and transparency elements. ([HEPI](#))

♦ Arguments For Retaining/Adjusting the Loan System

Access & risk

- Tuition loans arguably maintain broad **access to higher education**, especially for lower-income students, because there is no upfront payment needed.

State share of costs

- Changing to a full graduate tax or free tuition would shift costs to general taxation, which raises complex questions about fairness and fiscal impact.



5. Summary – Key Points for Research

Aspect	Current Position	Notes
Tuition fee loan cap	~£9,535 (2025/26)	Rising with inflation caps; planned further increases. (Wonkhe)
Loan repayment threshold	~£25,000/year	Repay 9% of income above threshold (Plan 5). (MoneySavingExpert.com)
Repayment duration	Up to 40 years (Plan 5)	Longer than previous plans; unfinished balances are written off after term. (NIESR)
Average debt	~£53,000	Reflects tuition + maintenance borrowing. (The Guardian)
Public perceptions	Often inaccurate	Evidence from HEPI/KCL. (HEPI)
Debate focus	Fairness, sustainability	Graduate tax vs loan structure are key themes. (NIESR)



6. Further Reading & Useful Sources

Here are authoritative sources you might cite in your research:

- UK Parliament Research Briefings on student loans and higher education funding. ([House of Commons Library](#))
- Government statistics on student support (2025/26). ([GOV.UK](#))

- HEPI public perception study (2025). ([HEPI](#))
- IFS / NIESR commentary on Plan 5 and reform options. ([NIESR](#))

Asbestos

Disclaimer

19th Jan 2026

This content was generated using artificial intelligence via OpenAI's ChatGPT (version 5.2) in response to a natural-language prompt asking for an overview of the current UK position on the management and removal of asbestos in buildings, including relevant evidence, research, reports, and available data. The output is intended to support research and discussion and **must not** be relied upon as a substitute for professional, legal, or regulatory advice. Users are encouraged to verify information against primary sources and official guidance.

1. Current UK Policy: “Manage In Situ” by Default

Legal framework

- UK asbestos in buildings is governed principally by the **Control of Asbestos Regulations 2012** (CAR 2012). ([HSE](#))
- These regulations *do not mandate blanket removal* of all asbestos-containing materials (ACMs).
- Instead, they require that ACMs be **identified, assessed, risk-managed, monitored, and either left in place safely or removed if necessary** — based on risk assessment and specific circumstances. ([HSE](#))

This is often expressed as the legal duty to:

1. **Survey and identify** ACMs if a building was built or refurbished before 2000. ([HSE](#))
2. **Record location and condition** in a register. ([HSE](#))
3. **Assess risk of fibres being released** during normal use or maintenance. ([HSE](#))
4. **Manage, monitor and communicate** rather than automatically remove. ([HSE](#))

The dutyholder (building owner/manager) must implement a management plan and **review it annually**; asbestos that is *undamaged and undisturbed* typically remains in place. ([HSE](#))

2. Why “Leave In Place” Is the Default Approach

Risk-based approach

The UK's approach is *risk-based*:

- ACMs that are **intact and unlikely to be disturbed** pose *minimal risk* of fibre release. ([Research Briefings](#))
- Disturbing asbestos without need (e.g., unnecessary removal) can itself **increase the risk** of fibres becoming airborne and can expose workers and occupants. ([HSE](#))

As the HSE states: asbestos continues to be removed where necessary, *but much remains safely managed where disturbance isn't likely*. ([HSE](#))

3. Scale & Risk Evidence

Prevalence

- UK estimates suggest **~1.5 million buildings still contain asbestos** — largely pre-2000 buildings. ([Astutis](#))
- Common locations include schools, hospitals, offices and older residential buildings. ([Specialist Remediation Solutions](#))

Health impact

- Asbestos exposure remains a serious health issue:
 - ~5,000 UK deaths/year from asbestos-related diseases (mesothelioma, lung cancer, asbestosis). ([UKATA](#))
 - Mesothelioma deaths alone were 2,218 in 2023. ([UKATA](#))
- Because disease latency can be decades, *past exposures continue to drive current mortality*. ([UKATA](#))

Occupational risk

Construction workers and maintenance staff remain among the *highest exposure risk groups*. ([HSE](#))

4. Proposals & Policy Debate (Emerging Evidence / Calls for Change)

Although the current statutory position is *manage in situ*, there are **growing calls for a more proactive removal strategy**:

UK Parliament / Work and Pensions Committee Proposal

- A proposal (2025) recommended a *40-year programme to remove legacy asbestos* from public and commercial buildings rather than relying on in-place management. ([AWH Solicitors](#))
- It emphasises the need for data frameworks, more evidence on exposure and regional air monitoring, and resources for inspections and enforcement. ([AWH Solicitors](#))

Campaigner & media scrutiny

- Investigations (e.g., **Guardian reporting**) highlight that reliance on “leave in place” may be problematic, citing audits where a large share of ACMs were damaged and at higher risk if disturbed — and advocates for a *national removal strategy*. ([The Guardian](#))

Sector concern

- **Trade union reports** point out that two-thirds of surveyed NHS buildings still contain asbestos, highlighting ongoing risks even in critical public infrastructure. ([The Royal College of Nursing](#))

5. Key UK Reports & Sources to Support Evidence

Report / Guidance	Relevance
Control of Asbestos Regulations 2012 (HSE)	Core legal duty and management framework. (HSE)
HSE Asbestos Risk & General Info	Overview of health risks and industry stats. (HSE)
HSE Asbestos Health Statistics	Annual disease burden data. (UKATA)
Work & Pensions Committee Proposal	Latest parliamentary proposal on removal strategy. (AWH Solicitors)
Trade union / NHS estate surveys	Evidence of presence in critical buildings. (The Royal College of Nursing)
Media investigations	Independent scrutiny of policy effectiveness. (The Guardian)

6. Current Best Practice for Building Owners/Managers

If your building contains asbestos:

- ✓ Survey and record asbestos locations. ([HSE](#))
- ✓ Assess risk — especially if refurbishment/maintenance planned. ([HSE](#))
- ✓ Develop and update an asbestos management plan. ([HSE](#))
- ✓ Only *remove* asbestos if safe management cannot be maintained, or if work is likely to disturb it. ([HSE](#))
- ✓ Always use **licensed removal contractors** for regulated work. ([Supernova Asbestos Surveys](#))